

ABSTRACT OF PAPER

**XXI CONGRESS OF THE INTERNATIONAL ASSOCIATION FOR
CARIBBEAN ARCHAEOLOGY (IACA)
ON JULY 24-30, 2005**

HOSTED BY
THE DEPARTMENT OF HISTORY
THE UNIVERSITY OF THE WEST INDIES
AT THE LEARNING RESOURCE CENTRE
TRINIDAD AND TOBAGO

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INDIANS CAME TO THE CARIBBEAN BEFORE COLUMBUS

Abstract – People of South Asian/Indian origin in the Caribbean commemorate Indian Arrival Day annually to memorialize the advent of their forefathers to the New World in 1845 as indentured labourers from India. Little do they (and others) know that bands of Indian migrants had come to the Americas by crossing the strip of narrow land at the Bering Strait 13,000 years ago. The theory of diffusion which provides the basis of such a claim has been supported by recent archeological, historical and genetic discoveries. This paper interprets the material evidence left by the Mayans in Belize and the Amerindians in the Caribbean to support the hypothesis of Indian contact and influence. This paper will be read along with a slide presentation to illustrate the similarities between the ancient cultures of Middle America and Hindu India.

Keywords – Asian/Indian/Hindu migration; Historical Archaeology; New World; Caribbean

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INTRODUCTION

East Indians/South Asians came to the Caribbean and South America (Guyana, Suriname and French Guiana)) for a second time, from 1838. They came as indentured servants and labourers to work in the sugarcane, cocoa, coconut and coffee plantations after the abolition of slavery.

Recent archaeological and genetic research has shown that the movement of Indians from India to the western continents came centuries before Columbus landed on these shores. Eminent European scholar and anthropologist Baron Alexander von Humboldt was a pioneer in postulating the Asiatic origin of the Indian civilizations of the Americas. However, the early history of Asiamericans is shrouded in mystery and controversy due to the absence of definitive documentary evidence which was destroyed by the European conquerors in their misguided religious zeal.

The most important development of ancient American or Asiamerican culture took place in the south of the United States, Mexico, Central America, and Peru. Centuries before Columbus landed, Asian migrants had come to the western shores of these continents in vast numbers. South Asian Indians took with them their system of measurement of time, their local gods, and customs which included games, dances and ceremonies. It can, therefore, be argued that Hindus and Hopis, Advantins and Aztecs, Tibetan monks and Mayans priests are part of one global culture.

Many of the peoples of Southeastern Asia had adopted the trappings of the Indian-Buddhist civilizations. The influences of the Hindu-Buddhist culture of southeast Asia in Mexico, and particularly among the Maya, are incredibly strong. These apparent

influences have already disturbed some Americanists who do not like see, recognize, discuss or accept them. According to Swami B.V. Tripurari:

What mysterious psychological law would have caused Asians and Americans to both use the umbrella as an emblem of rank and a sign of royalty, to invent the same games with rather complicated rules, imagine similar cosmological systems, and to attribute certain colours to the different cardinal directions - south being red, east being blue etc.?

Colonel James Tod in his writings in the *Annals and Antiquities of Rajasthan: or the Central and Western Rajput States of India*, has said: "It is ridiculous with all the knowledge now in our possession, to suppose that the Hindus always confined themselves within their gigantic barriers, the limits of modern India."

ARCHITECTURE

Ephraim George Squier, author of "Peru: Incidents of Travel and Exploration in the land of the Incas," in comparing the temples of India, Java and Mexico has written: "a proper examination of these monuments would disclose the fact that in their interior as well as their exterior form and obvious purposes, these buildings (Palanque, Mexico) correspond with great exactness to those of Hindustan."

Sir Stamford Raffles, the British historian and founder of Singapore as a British colony, expressed a similar view: "[T]he great temple of Borobudur in Java might readily be mistaken for a Central American temple." In 1866, the French architect Eugene Viollet

de Luc noted striking resemblances between ancient Mexican architectural structures and those of South India, especially Buddhist temples.

METALLURGY

No archaeologist today would attribute to prehistoric Europeans the independent invention of the wheel, bronze casting, iron work, weaving, pottery, writing and so many other cultural elements derived from the Near East. Thus what is not conceded to the inhabitants of the British Isles is willingly conceded to the American Indians. It is a paradox to believe that a whole series of complicated techniques, like casting by the lost wax method, the extraction of tin from cassiterite, the alloying copper and tin, the colouring of gold by chemical processes, weaving, tie-dyeing and batik were invented twice - once in the Old World and once in America?

The first Maya Empire had been founded in Guatemala around the beginning of the Christian era. Before the fall of Rome the Mayans were accurately charting the synodical revolutions of Venus. And while Europe was still lingering in the Dark Ages, the Maya civilization had reached a peak of greatness. It is also significant that the zenith of Mayan civilization was reached at a time when India had also attained an unparalleled cultural peak during the Gupta period. Moreover, Indian cultural intercourse with Southeast Asia had begun more than a century before the Mayan classical age in 320, and Buddhism and Hinduism has been well known in neighboring countries for centuries.

If there were contact between Mayan America and Indianized South East Asia, the simultaneous cultural advance would not appear surprising. In marked contrast, this

was the darkest period in Europe's history between the sack of Rome and the rise of Charlemagne.

HINDU-MEXICAN TRINITY

Scholars are also greatly impressed by the similarity between the Hindu Trinity - Brahma-Vishnu-Shiva and the Mexican Trinity, *Ho Huizilopochtli-Tlaloc*, as well as the likeness between Indian temples and American pyramids.

THE INDIAN ELEPHANT

The Indian elephant *Elephas indicus* is a species found in India, Ceylon, Borneo and Sumatra. This species was tamed during the Vedic period. The Mayan long-nosed god is regarded by those who favor the hypothesis of direct or indirect Indian cultural influence in America as a form of the Indian elephant-headed god. (e.g in Stella B at Copan).

MOTHER OF THE GODS

The Hindu goddess Maya, "mother of gods and men" was carried to America and appeared in the Mayan theogony of Yucatan under the same name. Maya has the same functions that she performs in India. In Mexico, Maya was also called "the mother of the gods."

THE TREE OF HEAVEN

The Tree of Heaven of South Asia also appears in Palenque, Mexico, and is called the "cross." It bears striking similarities to the tree of heaven from Java.

THE MAKARA MOTIF

The *makara* motif is a serpent head with upturned snout and with a human face in its mouth. This is found in India, Java, Bali and Sumatra. It is comparable to the Mexican *Xiuhcoati*.

GOD ON THE LION THRONE

The Mexican Lion throne and the lotus throne show very close similarities to the Indian *Simhasana* and *Padmasana*.

GAMES

Games such as the *pachisi* of India and the Mexican *patoli* are very similar. E.B. Tyler, author of "On the Game of Patolli in ancient Mexico and its Probably Asiatic Origin" (1879), concluded that Mesoamerican lot games were not the only ideas brought from Asia, but so too were certain developments in all areas in developing a new society.

ASTRONOMY

Both the Hindus and Mesoamericans used similar items in their worship rituals. They both maintained the concept of four *Yuga* cycles or cosmological seasons extending over thousands of years and conceived of twelve constellations with reference to the sun as indicated by the Incan sun calendar.

Royal insignias, systems of government, and practice of religious dance and temple worship all showed remarkable similarities, pointing strongly to the idea that the Mesoamericans were strongly influenced by the Aryans. The ancient *Puranas* and the *Mahabharata* make mention of the Americas as lands rich with gold and silver. Argentina, which means "related to silver" is thought to have been named after *Arjuna* ("of the silver hue").

Dr. B. Chakravarti author of "The Indians and the Amerindians" has written: "It will be evident from a close study of the texts of Indian Astronomy that Latin America was known to ancient Indians, who called it *Pataldesa*. The *Surya Siddhartha*, a Textbook of Astronomy composed before 500 A.D. identifies and describes *Pataldesa* in very clear and definite terms. The *Surya Siddhartha* categorically says that the *Devas* and *Asuras* live on the earth; The *Devas* live in the northern hemisphere while the *Asuras* live in the Southern Hemisphere and have a tradition of enmity against each other. It further says that the ocean which surrounds the poles of the earth has divided the planet into two great continents, the continent of the *Devas* and the continent of the *Asuras*. The

Brahmanas of India wrote the epithet *Deva-Serman* after their names, thus describing themselves as the *Devas*.

When the sun is in the northern hemisphere, for example in Aries, it appears first to the *Devas*, and again when the sun is in the southern hemisphere, it appears first to the *Asuras*. When the sun is on the equator, both the *Devas* and the *Asuras* find the sun in the middle, and the days are equal. As the sun proceeds to the northern hemisphere, the *Devas* experience summer because of the directness and intensity of the solar rays. The *Asuras* do not get the rays directly and the intensity is less - the sun being in the northern hemisphere. Theefore, they experience winter during this time. This obviously indicates that *Pataldesa* was in South America.

Maya, the author of *Surya Siddhartha*, also mentions the four great cities situated on the opposite ends of the world equidistant from one other: 1. *Yamakotipura* in *Bhadravavarsa* (Indonesia?) in the east; 2. Lanka in *Bharatvarsa* (India) in the South; 3. Rome in *Ketumalavarsa* (Europe) in the west; and 4. *Siddhapura* in *Kuruvarsa* (America?) in the north.

NAVIGATION

Anthropologist Dr. Robert Heine Geldern (1966) has written: "Those who believe the ancient peoples of Asia were incapable of crossing the ocean have completely lost sight of what the literary sources tell us concerning the ships and their navigation. Ships that could cross the Indian Ocean were able to cross the Pacific too. Moreover, these ships

were really larger and probably more seaworthy than those of Columbus and the Magellan."

Aryan words and people came to America through the island chains of Polynesia. The very name of "boat" in Mexico is a South Indian (Tamil) word *catamaran* according to Ambassador Miles Poindexter (1930). He continues: "Hindus were mighty navigators and pioneers of cultures centuries before Columbus was born. They established their cultural empires in Java, Balim, Sumatra, Borneo, Philippines, Cambodia, Champa, Burma, Thailand, and ruled there until the 14th century.

From such location of places around the globe, and the movement towards the east, it appears that many Indian merchants used to sail frequently. Some even settled in Indonesia and Indochina. This was a relay point to Polynesia, and then further on to South or Middle America. These trips were not always in single ships or in a single effort, but stopovers at important ports on other island chains *en route* which were in existence then. Some of these islands were submerged later because of tectonic movements.

The Periplus of the Erythrean Sea mentions the large ships of Southern India which engaged in trade with countries of the east. A Chinese source of the third century A.D. describes vessels from southern Asia which were 150 feet in length, had four masts, and were able to carry 600 to 700 men, and one thousand metric tons of merchandise.

DIVINITY

The Mayan human types are like those of India. The irreproachable technique of their reliefs and the sumptuous head-dress all speak that ancient contact between India and the Orient. Sir William Jones in his studies on Hinduism states: "Rama is represented as a descendant from the sun; as the husband of Sita; and the son of a princess named Causelya. It is very remarkable that Peruvians, particularly Incas, boasted of the same descent, and named their greatest festival *Rama-Sitva*. In South East Asia and in Asiomerica there is the belief in the four Hindu *Yugas* (epochs), the existence of the Hindu *Gurukala* scheme of education, the Hindu *panchayat* system, the bazaar economy, the *Soma Yagna* (sacrifice), the worship of Indra, and other Hindu gods and goddesses.

CONCLUSION

In conclusion, similar routines of everyday life of Indians and Asioamericans are commonplace. For example, betel-chewing with lime and cocoa and tobacco, as well as the existence of the gourd-container for the lime are common to both peoples. The Peruvian substitute for tobacco, which was used for medicinal purposes, was a shrub called *cuca* (coca). The leaves were first dried and mixed with lime to constitute a preparation for chewing. Vegetarianism is popular both in India and Mexico. The Indian *roti* or *chappati* and the Mexican *tortilla*, similar in size and shape are made in the same way. Both peoples have an unusual respect for corn and share the custom of offering bits of food to God in expression of their gratitude for the meal provided, before eating.

It is certain that cotton was first used in the Indus Valley. American cotton are tetraploid in chromosome constitution, and their chromosome complement is made up of

the one set of homologous with the complement of the diploid Asian cotton, and one set homologous with the complement of the diploid species of America. After a series of painstaking experiments scientists agree that one parent of the American cotton undoubtedly came from the Indus Valley area of Asia.

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